disappointed. They petitioned Ratan for a reduction in the eligibility criteria, but he would have none of it. He said that the award should be ‘coveted and received only when its standards were achieved’. The companies should improve their overall performance instead of asking for a dilution of standards. But he kept the group companies’ enthusiasm and spirit alive by giving recognition plaques instead to the three companies with the highest points. It was his signature management style of acknowledging effort and celebrating commitment.

The Tata Business Excellence Model

Four years after the institution of the JRD QV Award, in 1998, the programme was modified into the Tata Business Excellence Model (TBEM), ‘conceived to deliver strategic direction and drive business improvements at the Tata group’.

It provided for the companies to be assessed on seven core aspects of business operations: ‘leadership; strategic planning; customer and market focus; information and analysis; human resource focus; process management; and business results’. The first six categories were assigned a total of 550 points while the last entry was assigned the remaining 450.

While implementing the programme, Ratan worked to underplay the reputational damage that accompanied any poor grading. He said that the award was a recognition of the ground the companies had covered to achieve the required milestone. It was not meant to be ‘a prize’. But he also underscored its importance: ‘There needs to be a recognition that quality both in terms of the product and in terms of the manner in which one conducts their businesses is very important to a successful enterprise.’

After the introduction of the TBEM, Ratan pushed companies harder to strive for excellence. By 2000, the results were evident. In the AGMM held that year, the first JRD QV awardee was declared. The winner was Tata Steel, the largest company in the group’s stable. A visibly pleased Ratan said: ‘Strangely enough … Tata Steel would have been the last company I would have thought would win the award. I do not mean that derogatorily.’ He added that as Tata Steel was operating in a large traditional industry that had enjoyed seller’s market conditions, he did not expect it to shed its old ways and adopt competitive practices so quickly. He heaped encomiums on Tata Steel for doing a ‘remarkable job of transforming themselves’.